

Hitachi develops 7mm drive

Hitachi develops a 7mm thick laptop hard drive; it's named the Travelstar Z5K500

Minecraft goes beta

The popular online multiplayer game Minecraft has left beta; price is bumped up to 20 Euros

The lack of camera and video calling might also put off some of the buyers.

But we have to admit that the experience of using a 10-inch tablet is completely different. Yes, you might be robbed of little pleasures like holding the tablet and reading a long book without developing joint problems (ok, a little exaggerated, but it's not easy holding the iPad). But, the screen estate helps many aspects, typing not the least. The large screen and a very well laid-out multi-touch keyboard make typing on the iPad much more pleasing. Even the copy/paste of iOS is much more usable than on Android. And we love the little magnifier that helps in positioning the cursor while editing text, something we have to do with a blind eye on Android.

Another factor that works for the iPad is the excellent apps from Apple's 'App Store'. Apple's is a closed system, where every app is scrutinised in a way that not everyone appreciates. But you cannot hide the fact that almost every 'App Store' app is more functional and refined than its counterpart on Android or other platforms. And you are way less likely to encounter problems due to compatibility issues.

The iPod based music app is one of the best in the category. The iPad now has our favorite VLC Player ported to it, playing almost all formats.

But the open-source Android still has some pluses over the closed iOS. Android's notification bar is the envy of many Apple users. And not everyone can put up with the nonsense of having to

use iTunes to transfer everything to the device. Overall, we recommend Android to the slightly adventurous people, and iOS to those who like stability.

Weight and size are major issues with the iPad. Consider this: Even Apple fanboys are eagerly waiting for the expected 7-inch iPad. Since Apple don't officially sell it in India, the price at which you land one could vary greatly. We got it directly from the US for about 34,000 bucks, but you might have to shell out as much as 50,000 to pick up one from the grey market. We strongly recommend against the device if you are at the wrong end of the pricing: It is not worth anything above 40,000.

VIEWSONIC VIEWPAD 7

ViewPad 7 is build solidly, but is a little on the heavier and thicker side. The back is good quality plastic with a glossy finish that loves capturing fingerprints. Although, we didn't receive the OlivePad for testing, we were surprised to see that the ViewPad and OlivePad seem to be the same devices.

The low-DPI screen has poor viewing angles, especially under bright sunlight. The touchscreen of the device is a disappointment too. Besides not being very responsive, it has issues with the multi-touch.

All four Android buttons made it to the tablet, the lights under the buttons are not linked to screen and go off in about four seconds. This really annoyed us, especially while thumbing the tablet at night.

The tablet has a very slow processor at 600MHz, and it is apparent while using the tablet. Also, we were dumbstruck when we tried opening a Flash site. This tablet does not support Flash, even though it runs Android 2.2! In fact, we did doubt if it could handle Flash.

The onscreen keyboard has, however, been changed by Viewsonic, and works better than the stock Android one. The document editor 'Documents To Go' is one of the better bundled office suites we saw in our tablet test.

The thing that miffed us the most was the lack of internal storage on the device, coupled with the oversight of the company to not even bundle a

HOW WE TESTED

While testing the build of the device, we consider the overall quality of materials, screen surface and buttons. Unibody and metallic bodies were given higher marks than plastic bodies. The tablets with a scratch-resistant screen scored more. Metallic/capacitive buttons were preferred over plastic/resistive buttons. Loose parts attracted a penalty. We tested the display indoors and in sunlit conditions, running videos and noting the picture quality. Text legibility was tested using the in-built e-book reader, in both indoor and sunlit conditions. We tested the performance by going through top 10 flash-based web sites for flash-enabled tablets (check out 'Unwind' on pg. 118). We also tried graphic intensive games (Homerun Battle 3D, Angry Birds: Seasons) to gauge the performance of the devices. Video performance was tested by running a video at highest resolution supported. Time needed to return to home screen abruptly from within these sites, games and videos was noted. For ergonomics, we considered handling experience, UI and interface, response and feedback of buttons, touch-screen response, and smudging of touch screen and body. We looked for matte finished backs, responsive and touch-friendly UIs. In rating the on-screen keyboard we considered the following parameters – layout and usability, effectiveness of word-prediction, multi-touch support, Swype or other techniques.

memory card. Personally, we wouldn't shell out ₹32,000 for this tablet.

SMC STYLEPAD AND INFIBEAM ANDROID PHI

SMC's EZ StylePad and Infibeam's Android-based Phi are brothers from another mother. Both are based on Android, but are not in the same bracket as rich-boys'-toys Dell Streak and Samsung Galaxy Tab. You have to compromise with poor build quality on the outside, and buggy hardware on the inside.

THE UGLY

Resistive touchscreens have a tough time on larger displays. Because the distance between the two layers that make up a resistive touch device has

